Rains" which are convectional rains. Rainfall decreases towards the interior.



In equatorial regions convectional rain occurs almost daily in the afternoons. It generally occurs at 4pm that's why it is known as 4' o Clock Rain.

Drainage

Owing to the position of the Andes all the great rivers of the continent drain into the Atlantic. The Pacific streams are short and swift but along the coastlands of Peru their waters are used for irrigation and to some extent for hydro-electric power. Amazon is the longest river of South America (6,450km) and is the largest river system in the world. This river have over a thousand of tributaries. The rivers Rio Negro, Madeira and Tapajos are important tributaries. At the point where it enters the sea the river is so wide and powerful that it flows even at a distance of 80 km into the high seas. The Orinoco River originates in the Guiana Highlands and flows northwards into the Caribbean Sea. The river Paraguay has the Paraná and Uruguay rivers as the main tributaries which together form and known as the Platte River system. All the rivers are navigable for quite some distance in the interior.



Amazon is the greatest river of South America and the largest drainage system in the world in terms of the volume of its flow and the area of its basin.

Natural Vegetation

There are four main natural vegetation areas of South America and are the Amazon basin (the Selvas), the Eastern Highlands, the Gran Chaco and the slopes of the Andes. The Selvas of the equatorial regions are called the "lungs of the world". The Amazon rainforest are the largest of their kind in the world. They abound in hardwood trees such as mahogany and Ebony which are very valuable. The other common species are Rosewood Cinchona and a variety of Palm trees. The bark of the cinchona tree is used for making quinine - the drug to cure Malaria. The Amazon rainforest are gradually getting depleted. Various developmental activities such as construction of transportation lines, human settlements and agriculture have led to widespread deforestation. Environmentalist fear that this might lead to serious ecological disturbance in future.



Amazon rainforest

The Eastern Highlands have many varieties of trees which are of economic importance. The leaves of the Yerba Mate tree are used to make you tea - like drink. The Gran Chaco region has thick deciduous forests. An important hardwood tree found in these forests is the Quebracho Tree (axe breaker). Quebracho tree yields tannin which is used for tanning leather. The forests

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